

VISUAL IDENTITY SOP

GOH CONSULTING

Goal

Give you the complete process to engineer your visual identity so that anyone who lands on your content decides you're worth watching in the first second — before you say a single word.

What this is

Your visual identity is every visual cue your audience takes in before they process what you're actually saying: your location, lighting, camera quality, audio, and clothing. This SOP shows you how to make all five intentional so your brand is perceived as high-level on autopilot — even when the words never change.

The one rule this whole SOP hangs off

THE ONE RULE

Your audience decides whether to trust you before you speak — so make every visual cue intentional, and fix the cause before the effect.

People form an opinion of you the instant they see you, based entirely on how you look. That's not fair — it's human nature, the same wiring that makes luxury brands spend billions on packaging. You can't switch it off, so you use it.

Everything here is a “cause.” Hooks, scripts, and offers are the “effect.” If the cause is broken, the best hook in the world won't hit — which is why your visual identity is 70% of everything.

Why it matters

Anyone can tidy up a caption. Almost nobody is intentional about how they look on camera, which is exactly why it's the easiest lever you can pull — a detail no one else pays attention to, so when you do, it becomes your unfair advantage. If your first impression doesn't say "I'm someone worth listening to," nobody sticks around to find out you know your stuff.

Bonus: it's the cheapest, fastest lever in the entire brand. You can meaningfully fix it in about three hours for a small budget, and every improvement compounds over every video you ever post.

EXAMPLE — THREADED THROUGH THIS SOP

Before I dialled this in, I wore whatever I felt like — a singlet, a plain athletic t-shirt, a hoodie — filmed in the same spot with the ceiling light on. I looked like everybody else. I set aside two weeks and about \$1,000, built a Pinterest board, chose three to five locations, and rebuilt my wardrobe around three words: clean, minimalistic, smart. Nothing about my message changed. The growth in the brand did.

When to use this

Use it before you script or film anything for your personal brand, when you audit underperforming content, when you set up a new filming location, and before every batch recording session.

- **When not to use it:** Don't let perfecting gear become the reason you stop posting — your iPhone is good enough to build real perception, so start now and upgrade later. And don't use it to fake a life you don't live.

Who owns it

You, the brand owner, own your visual identity — nobody can outsource their own face and taste. If you have a creative director or content team, they execute the lighting, camera, and audio with you. If not, you run all five pillars yourself. Everything here is doable solo.

Before you start

- **ICP clarity:** Know exactly who you're talking to — your ideal client profile, the one dream person you want to attract. If your program uses a "dream follower

worksheet”, fill it out first; your whole visual standard is set by what this person responds to.

- **Your three words:** Pick the three words that describe the image you want to project (mine: clean, minimalistic, smart). Every choice should serve those words.
- **A small budget:** Roughly \$1,000 for clothing and \$50–\$200 for a microphone covers almost everyone.
- **Three to five filming locations:** Ones you can access (see Pillar 1).
- **The gear list:** Your program shares a gear list of specific lights, cameras, and mics at different budgets — use it to decide what to buy.

The process: the 5 pillars

Visual identity is built on five pillars, run in this order: Environment & Location, Lighting, Camera, Audio, Clothing. One or two dialled in already lifts you above the feed; all five make your content look and feel like a different brand.

Pillar 1: Environment & location

- **Goal:** Make your background actively raise your perceived value instead of quietly lowering it.

Your background communicates something whether you intend it to or not. Your ICP isn't just listening — they're looking at where you are and asking “is this someone I want to be like?” If it's unintentional, your content looks like everybody else's.

- **Rotate 3–5 locations:** Filming the same one or two spots makes you creatively flat and shows your audience only one dimension of you. Rotating keeps content fresh and lets more of who you are come through.
- **Where to film:** Anywhere your ICP aspires to spend time — a main office, living room, co-working space, nice hotel lobby, rooftop, or good coffee shop.

Ways to source great locations — pick what fits your budget and week:

- **1. Hire a studio (2–3 hrs):** Batch record a week of content.
 - **Pros:** Controlled, reliable, efficient — one trip covers many videos.
 - **Cons:** Costs money; can feel less “real life” than a lived-in space.
- **2. Book an Airbnb for a weekend:** Treat it as a shoot plus a mini holiday.
 - **Pros:** Premium aesthetic, fun, lots of angles in one place.
 - **Cons:** The biggest spend of the three; needs planning.
- **3. Use free public spaces:** Coffee shops, rooftops, co-working spots, hotel lobbies.

- **Pros:** Free or cheap, endless variety, real environments.
- **Cons:** You have to scout quiet times and manage noise and foot traffic.
- **Vary your angles:** Shoot three within a location: direct-to-camera, a side angle that still shows the view, and a ~45° angle. Changing angles stops the content feeling flat.
- **Stay true to your lifestyle:** Use aspirational but real-to-you spaces. Filming in five-star hotels you don't live in reads as fake and people see through it.

Pillar 2: Lighting

- **Goal:** Look flattering, professional, and trustworthy anywhere you film, using light you understand rather than gear you can't carry.

Lighting is the single highest-leverage change you can make — nothing transforms video quality more dramatically for less money. Once you understand the concepts you can apply them with natural light alone.

- **Key light:** Your main source and ~90% of the job — a ring light with a soft box, or a window facing you. Buy this first; for most people it's the only one they need.
- **Fill light:** A weaker light that softens the shadow the key light creates. A window can be your fill. Without it, one side of your face goes very dark.
- **Back / background light:** The least important, but it lifts your background out of darkness and adds depth so your image feels 3D. Even a basic lamp works.
- **Position at 45°:** Never straight on — that's flat and ordinary. At 45° you get a controlled shadow that, softened by a fill, reads as the cinematic “roll-off” you see in films.
- **Not just for dark rooms:** Film against a strong window with no key light and you become a silhouette; add a key light and that same view becomes a premium shot.
- **Build the mindset:** Walk into any space and map it: “window is my key light, ceiling light could be fill, corner lamp is my background light.” Always find your key light first.
- **What to buy:** One key light that travels well, sets up fast, and runs on batteries so you can use it outside. Add fill and background lights only when you want to go further.

Pillar 3: Camera quality

- **Goal:** Match your image quality to what your ICP expects, without letting gear become an excuse not to post.

- **1. Mirrorless camera:** Highest image quality; dedicated to filming so you use it with intent.
 - **Pros:** Best quality, HDMI, USB-C power, forces higher-quality content.
 - **Cons:** Most expensive; more setup and workflow friction.
- **2. The Osmo (pocket camera):** A small dedicated camera.
 - **Pros:** Dedicated to filming, portable, intentional to use.
 - **Cons:** Costs money; still a device to manage.
- **3. Your iPhone:** You already own it — great for authentic candid content.
 - **Pros:** Free, always with you, great for candid clips.
 - **Cons:** Your whole life is on it, so filming can feel less intentional.

Your iPhone is genuinely good enough to build real perception — gear is never a reason not to post. Use a real camera for main sit-down videos where production value matters, and treat the phone as a format for candid, talking-head, and behind-the-scenes moments.

- **Let your ICP set the standard:** A fitness coach on the beach with a phone matches their world; someone speaking to high-level entrepreneurs should be on lighting and a proper camera. You can even ask on your onboarding form what content your audience responds to.
- **Resolution & frame rate:** Shoot the highest resolution your device allows. iPhone: 4K30 (Apple optimises autofocus, colour, and stabilisation at 30fps). Osmo/camera: 4K24 (film standard); use 25fps in the UK/Europe to avoid flicker. If phone footage flickers, turn on the power-saving-frequency toggle.
- **Orientation:** Film everything horizontal — vertical can't be reused for long form. For short form, crop or add borders. Pricier cameras (~\$5–6k) have “open gate” to crop vertical with no quality loss.
- **Framing (rule of thirds):** Camera at eye level or slightly above, never looking down or up. Turn on the grid and place your eyes just above the top gridline.
- **Safe zones:** Keep text and key content away from the edges so nothing gets cut off by the app interface.
- **Slow motion (the exception):** Only for a specific slow-mo B-roll shot — film at 50, 60, or 120fps. Most people rarely need this.

Pillar 4: Audio

- **Goal:** Sound crisp enough that people trust and stay — audio is the cue they feel but can't name.

Audio is the most overlooked pillar and it quietly kills content. People tolerate average video; they won't tolerate bad audio. When a video "just hits", the audio is usually crisp; when it sounds like a tin can, people leave.

- **DJI Mic Mini (~\$50):** The bare minimum — and it already produces great results.
- **DJI Mic 3 (wireless clip-on):** A step up when you want better wireless audio.
- **Shotgun mic:** For when you don't want to clip anything on — point it directly at your mouth.
- **Get it right in camera:** Never film in a loud environment thinking you'll fix it later — a great mic in a noisy room still gives bad audio, and heavy AI cleanup lowers quality. For unavoidable noise, run audio through Adobe Podcast before your editor's normal processing.

Pillar 5: Clothing

- **Goal:** Dress so that what you wear gives people a reason to keep watching before you've said a word.

What you wear tells your audience your professionalism, taste, and self-awareness — it either earns a second look or earns a scroll. There's no neutral.

- **Step 1 — decide the image you want:** Not who you are today, the person you're becoming. Don't jump to a look you can't carry — hoodies to a tuxedo won't read as you.
- **Step 2 — find your aesthetic:** Study how creators and leaders you respect dress, and what visual language your ICP responds to. Build a Pinterest board over about a week to set your style once and guide every purchase.
- **Step 3 — build a small, intentional wardrobe:** Five to ten on-brand outfits you feel confident in and that look intentional on camera.

Exactly what I bought to live my Pinterest board, in two weeks for ~\$1,000:

- **Three pairs of jeans:** Black, raw denim, dark blue.
- **One pair of pleated trousers:** Slightly more formal.
- **Simple quality basics:** Fitted t-shirts, clean polos, minimal knitwear.
- **One statement piece:** A leather jacket.
- **The principle — exaggerate your image:** The camera compresses everything, so push whatever you want to communicate slightly further than feels natural and it reads as normal on screen.

What good looks like

Watch your last five pieces back with brutal honesty. If your visual identity is dialled in, all of these are true:

- **You would actually stop and watch yourself.**
- **Your face is well lit with a soft shadow on one side — not flat, not a silhouette.**
- **The background is intentional, somewhere your ICP aspires to be, and it changes across your content.**
- **Angles vary within a piece rather than one static shot.**
- **Audio is crisp, recorded in a quiet space.**
- **Your outfit is on brand and matches your three words.**
- **Every single thing in the frame is there on purpose.**

Common mistakes

- **Same one or two backgrounds:** You go creatively flat and your audience sees one dimension of you — rotate between three to five locations.
- **LARPing a lifestyle you don't live:** People see through it and you lose trust — film in aspirational but real-to-you spaces.
- **No key light:** Relying on the ceiling light or filming against a window makes your face go dark or silhouetted — add a 45° key light, even a single travel light.
- **Filming vertical:** You can never reuse it for long form — film horizontal and crop or add borders for short form.
- **Bad or noisy audio:** Planning to fix it in post lowers quality and people leave on bad sound — use a mic and record in quiet rooms.
- **Default t-shirt with no thought:** You look like everyone else — spend two to three minutes on an intentional, on-brand outfit.
- **Eyes centred or too high:** The framing feels amateur — eyes just above the top rule-of-thirds line, camera at eye level or slightly above.

Edge cases and exceptions

- **Your ICP lives on a phone:** For a fitness or on-the-move audience, iPhone content for day-to-day posts matches their world.
- **You're in the UK or Europe:** Use 25fps on cameras instead of 24 to avoid flicker from mains lighting.
- **You want a slow-motion shot:** Break the 24/30fps rule and film at 50, 60, or 120fps for that clip only.

- **Filming outdoors:** Go during the day and use natural light — just a tripod and camera, no big key light. Carry a key light only for indoor spaces. Hiring a videographer ~once a month to carry gear and shoot angles pays for itself.
- **A busy, noisy hotel lobby:** Order a coffee or meal, be genuinely warm to staff, learn the manager's name, and tip in cash while explaining you're a creator wanting a quieter area — nine times out of ten they open a private space.
- **You have no camera yet:** Don't wait — the iPhone is good enough to build perception, so post now and upgrade later.

Things to note

- **Polar extremes win:** Bryan Johnson's obsession is exactly why a specific ICP resonates with him and why his visual identity is unmistakable. You don't need his budget — you need his mindset: every detail matters, and people notice even when they can't explain why.
- **The detail nobody else pays attention to is your advantage:** Most creators gloss over these pillars — being obsessive about the small stuff is how you pull ahead of people only thinking about hooks and scripts.
- **It's fast and cheap:** You can fix most of your visual identity in about three hours — order a few pieces, order a mic, change camera settings, reposition your light. Stop delaying.
- **Don't obsess so hard you stop shipping:** Filming beats not filming — work with what you have and improve one pillar at a time.

Quick checklist

Run this First Impression Checklist before every batch recording session. Answer each yes or no — and don't hit record until they're all yes.

Location and framing

- ☐ Is this one of my three to five rotating locations, and somewhere my ICP aspires to be?
- ☐ Is it real to my actual lifestyle, not a look I am faking?
- ☐ Have I planned more than one angle for this piece (direct, side, 45 degree)?
- ☐ Is the camera at eye level or slightly above, with my eyes just above the top rule-of-thirds line?

Lighting

- ☐ Is my key light on and at a 45 degree angle, so my face is not flat?

- ☐ Is the shadow side softened by a fill (a second light or a window)?
- ☐ Is there some light on the background for depth, so I am not a silhouette?

Camera

- ☐ Is the lens clean?
- ☐ Am I at the right resolution and frame rate (4K30 on iPhone, 4K24 on camera, 25 in UK/Europe)?
- ☐ Am I filming horizontal?
- ☐ Does the camera quality match what my ICP expects?

Audio

- ☐ Is my mic on and pointed at or clipped near my mouth?
- ☐ Is the room quiet enough that background noise will not ruin the take?

Clothing and overall image

- ☐ Is my outfit on brand and one of my five to ten intentional pieces?
- ☐ Do my three words (e.g. clean, minimalistic, smart) show up in everything on screen?
- ☐ If someone screenshotted this frame right now, would it say “worth listening to”?
- ☐ Bottom line: would I stop scrolling to watch myself?

Gaps to confirm

These points were referenced but not fully specified in the source material. Confirm them before this SOP is handed out:

- **The gear list:** Specific recommended lights, cameras, lenses, and mics at each budget were promised as a separate list — attach the current one.
- **Exact mic models:** Confirm current recommended models beyond the DJI Mic Mini (~\$50) and DJI Mic 3, plus the recommended shotgun mic.
- **Key light model:** Confirm the recommended battery-powered, travel-friendly key light.
- **Referral offer:** A promotion of \$3,000 for referring one client (to fund gear) was described as running “for the next month” — confirm whether it’s still live. Internal and time-sensitive.
- **Upload location:** Recordings and resources were said to live in “Brand Architect” — confirm exact location and access. Internal.
- **The 70% figure:** The founder’s stated conviction, not a measured statistic — keep as a claim, not a data point.